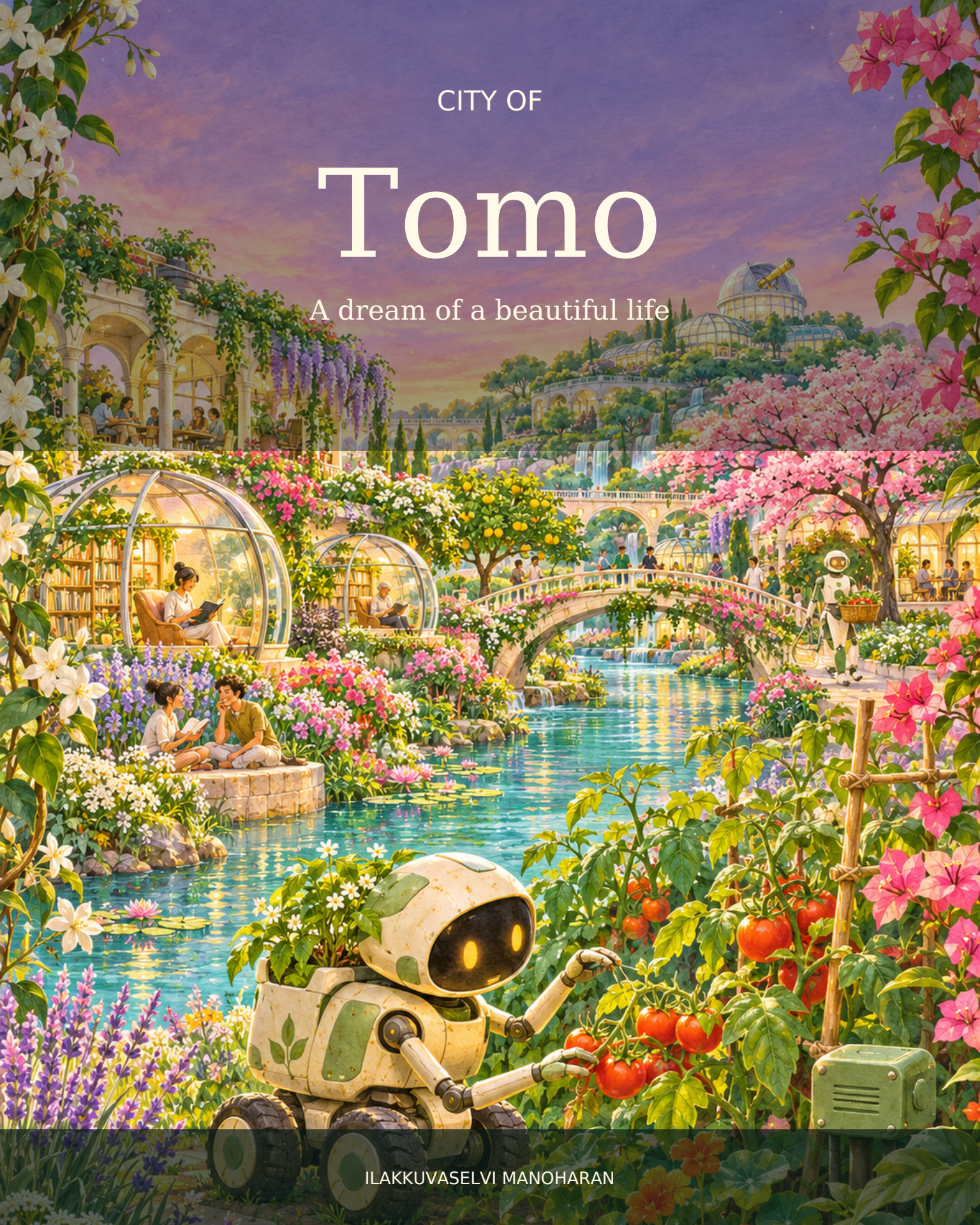
CITY OF
Tomo
A dream of a beautiful life
ILAKKUVASELVI MANOHARAN

City of Tomo

A dream of a beautiful life

For the generation that plants,
and the generation that will travel among stars.

May both learn to make a home.

Ilakkuvaselvi Manoharan

A walk through the city

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A place to wake up

There was enough morning for everyone.

01

The morning had room

The first thing Mira noticed was the sound of water. It passed beneath her window with the unhurried confidence of something that would still be there tomorrow. Beyond it, the city opened in terraces of green: beans climbing balconies, fruit trees shading doorways, gardens where she remembered roads ought to be.

She had arrived the night before with a small bag and an old habit of worrying. Even now, sunlight on the quilt, she was counting the things a day could demand of her. Rent. Breakfast. A reason to justify resting. Somewhere a bird began an extravagant song without explaining its usefulness.

At the garden gate, a little robot was waiting for a snail to cross the path. Its cream shell held the morning light. Two amber eyes shone above four sturdy wheels; a slender arm kept a watering nozzle still.

“That is TOMO,” said Leela from the neighboring balcony. “Come down when you are ready.”

Mira looked for the urgency inside the invitation. There was none. The kettle was warm. The garden was awake. For the first time in years, the morning seemed to have room for her.

There was enough morning for everyone.

02

Breakfast belonged to the day

Under an arbor heavy with grapes, breakfast was already happening. Someone was tearing warm bread. A humanoid with flour on its forearms carried a tray of idlis from a kitchen fragrant with ginger. A tiny delivery robot arrived with strawberries, taking the last corner very seriously.

Mira reached into her bag. Leela touched her wrist lightly. “You can leave that there.”

“How does this work?”

Leela told her about an old comparison: the city as a cruise ship. People had once paid into a common system through taxes, then paid again at the moment they needed to eat. The first neighborhoods had begun by making shared provision visible. You had already helped provide the kitchen; breakfast did not need a second gate.

Here, generations later, the comparison had become an old story. No one carried money. The gardens, kitchens, water, homes, and machines were held in common. Resources were counted carefully, but people did not have prices attached to them.

Mira accepted a bowl of fruit. Its sweetness was ordinary. The strange part was the absence of a calculation afterward. Across the table, a child offered her the larger half of a peach.

— Hunger met a table, and the table had a place.

03

Where the streets went

The old road descended beneath an orchard. Leela led Mira to an overlook where a glass wall revealed the city below: quiet electric vehicles moving through ventilated tunnels, freight traveling separately, maintenance machines inspecting the walls. Emergency routes and accessible entrances were marked clearly. Underground life had its own patient order.

Above them, clover softened the ground once surrendered to traffic. A narrow river curved between gardens. You could float along its gentle current or choose a dry pod that followed the water, close a transparent canopy, and read. Paths ran beside it for wheels and feet, with bridges, resting places, and ways out wherever people needed them.

Mira chose a pod. On its seat lay a book someone had finished and left for whoever came next. There was no advertisement on the canopy. The city did not ask her to buy anything while she traveled through it.

At the next bridge, a river guardian was checking a depth sensor. A storm upstream could change the afternoon; the pretty water was still water. The pod slowed near a family crossing.

Under the trees, time stopped resembling a thing she was forever late to catch.

The surface belonged to living.

The smallest beginning

One garden. A remembered place. A gentle action.

04

A small robot, a particular plant

TOMO stopped beside a tomato plant with a bent bamboo stake. Mira would have called it one plant among many. TOMO knew it as the same living neighbor it had visited yesterday.

The little robot looked at the leaves, approached the root zone, and lowered a probe. Its arms could extend and fold, precise enough to work among stems; its wheels carried it over the garden path. It did not rush through the bed as though speed were kindness.

Beside a rosemary bush stood a modest green box. “That is the garden node,” Leela said. “It keeps the history here.”

TOMO had brought the newest observation. The node remembered recent watering and rain, the plant's location, and an earlier reading that had seemed uncertain. Today's task allowed another measurement before any water was given. TOMO waited, measured again, and dispensed a small recorded amount.

Later, it would return to see what had changed. Care included the afterward.

Mira watched the nozzle lift without touching the leaves. The whole city suddenly seemed hidden inside this exchange: a place remembered, a need considered, an action taken gently, and someone returning to find out whether it helped.

The smallest complete beginning was a garden.

05

Many shapes of kindness

There were many robots like TOMO. They were not copies arranged in descending order of importance. Each had a body suited to somewhere and something.

A low, broad machine carried mulch without sinking deeply into the soft path. A tall orchard robot reached fruit that a child could only point at. Small floating machines read the pond. A quiet crawler inspected pipes. Humanoids worked where hands, stairs, and familiar tools made a human-shaped body useful: kneading dough, repairing shutters, changing the linen in a guest room.

The heavy hauling, repetitive cleaning, dangerous inspection, and tireless tending belonged to this varied company. People still made things with their hands. Someone spent a whole morning shaping a bowl badly and happily. A woman weeded because she liked the smell of disturbed soil. Nobody needed to turn pleasure into employment to defend the time it took.

At a workshop, Mira saw TOMO's arm laid open beside a larger robot's wrist. Both could be repaired. Parts were labeled, instructions available, tools shared.

There was affection in the machines' design, and also practicality. A city that trusted robots with its daily care had made room for their maintenance.

Different bodies carried the same promise of care.

A question in the field

The next generation grows among living things.

06

The classroom without a bell

By midmorning the children were in the bean field. One was measuring shade with a companion robot. Another had discovered a beetle and overturned the lesson by asking where the beetle slept.

Their teacher followed the question. Soon there were sketches of shelters, a discussion of leaves, and a small disagreement about whether shade could be measured with a ruler. The robot brought yesterday's observations. It could hold a magnifying lens steady; it could not decide which question a child ought to love.

Under the pavilion were books, quiet rooms, tactile models, and tables for anyone who preferred them. Reading, mathematics, history, and careful experiments were woven through the day. Some children wanted a predictable lesson. Others needed movement or a softer place to sit. The city had many doors into learning.

Mira remembered rows of desks and the fear of giving the wrong answer too slowly. Here a child could say, “I do not understand,” and the day widened around the sentence.

A boy asked whether robots could grow tomatoes on the Moon. His teacher handed him a notebook. “What would a tomato need there?”

The bean field became a doorway to space.

A question was allowed to change the afternoon.

07

The garden listened

Near the experimental beds, music drifted from a low speaker hidden beneath a shelter. A girl called Nila had chosen the melody for the morning: slow notes, almost transparent, threaded through the leaves.

“Is it for us?” Mira asked.

“For us too,” Nila said. The garden researchers were studying whether particular sound treatments changed particular plants' responses. Beside the musical bed was a quiet comparison bed, growing under otherwise similar conditions. The notes in Nila's notebook were more cautious than her enthusiasm.

Elsewhere, a small enclosure tested targeted acoustic signals as a way to discourage a specific pest. If a treatment did not help, or disturbed other creatures, they stopped it. Flowers, screens, careful observation, and beneficial insects remained part of the garden's care. There was no promise that one frequency could protect every crop.

Mira liked this unexpected tenderness toward uncertainty. Even in a city built from a dream, the gardeners did not ask a tomato to prove their favorite idea correct.

They sat awhile beneath the speakers. Beyond the trial beds, birds kept their own arrangements. The garden was full of sound, and enough silence to hear what answered.

Wonder could keep a notebook.

An evening beside the water

A table, a melody, a place to belong.

08

A table at the water

For the evening, Leela reserved a table beneath the pink lanterns. The reservation held a place and told the kitchen how many people were coming. It did not hold a payment.

“What if everyone wants the same table?” Mira asked.

“Then we take turns.” Leela smiled. “The view survives until tomorrow.” Popular evenings used a fair rotation; unclaimed places reopened. No family had a permanent claim on the water simply because its name was familiar.

The pond held silver fish and the wavering reflection of a moon not yet bright enough to be certain of itself. A floating guardian checked oxygen and temperature. A kitchen robot brought soup made with tomatoes from the morning garden. Mira recognized their sweetness and felt, absurdly, as if she had been introduced to an old friend.

At the far end of the terrace, musicians began tuning. People arrived without tickets, carrying shawls and sleepy children. The music was available at the point of showing up.

Nobody hurried them away when the bowls were empty. The table could be used for conversation. The city had planned for that kind of occupancy too.

An evening did not need to become a transaction.

09

The rain arrived early

The first drops darkened the tablecloth before the forecast expected them. A pond node had already noticed rising water upstream. Its message traveled to a bridge guardian and then to the river district, carrying a time, a place, and the uncertainty of the reading.

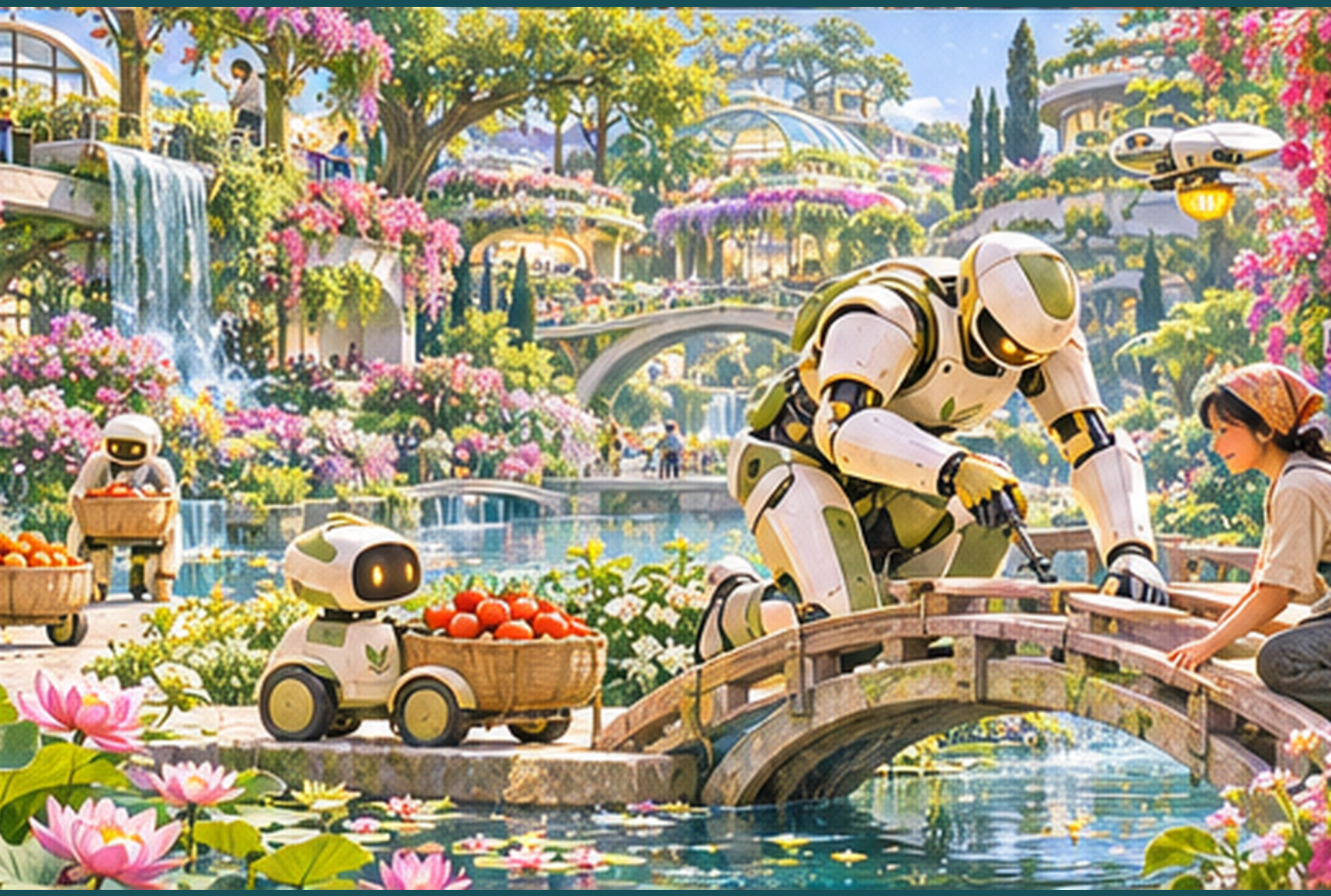
Pods were redirected before the lowest landing closed. A humanoid offered an arm to an older man on the wet steps. The musicians moved under the pavilion, laughing as they rescued a drum. Beneath the orchard, tunnel crews checked drainage and barriers.

TOMO paused its watering task. Rain near the concert did not prove rain had reached every tomato root; the garden node would wait for local evidence. Until then, an old plan could remain unfinished.

Mira watched a child lean into her mother's coat. The city was beautiful in the rain, but its beauty came partly from the things that were allowed to interrupt it: a warning, a changed route, a machine stopping rather than pretending to know.

By the time the music resumed, everyone had a dry place. Water gathered in the rain gardens. The pond took the sky in widening circles.

Being cared for included being allowed to change the plan.



The intelligence of care

Memory stays close to the place it serves.

10

The box beside the rosemary

The next morning, Leela opened the node's weatherproof cabinet. Inside were a computer, memory, and connections laid out with the neatness of a well-kept kitchen drawer. Some nodes carried a GPU for heavier perception and inference. Smaller gardens needed less.

Mira had expected a buried installation stretching beneath every plant. This garden's node sat on a raised pad beside the path. No trench had been opened for its data connection. Local wireless carried ordinary messages, and the dock offered another way to exchange them.

That simplicity had made the first garden easier to begin. It had not erased the ordinary needs of a computer outdoors. The cabinet had a tested power supply, cooling, seals, drainage clearance, and an accessible place for repair. Its placement respected heat, rain, and the possibility of floodwater. Leela checked a filter while she spoke.

From outside, the box looked almost shy. It did not need to resemble a monument to remember the garden faithfully.

TOMO approached with the latest leaf images. A long history remained in one place while a small body moved among living things.

The brain on the ground could be an ordinary box.

11

What, when, and how

The morning's plan was waiting: inspect the shaded bed, revisit the uncertain probe, water only where fresh evidence supported it, return before the battery reserve became too small.

The node owned the what and when. It held the garden's history, estimated its condition, and scheduled attention. TOMO owned the tactical work: finding a traversable approach, avoiding a hose, positioning its arm, measuring, and stopping if anything was wrong.

“The node does not steer every wheel?” Mira asked.

“No. A child might step into the path before a message could come back.”

Immediate movement and safety lived onboard. Motor and pump controls had their own watchdogs. A mission contained limits and an expiry, not an unlimited instruction to keep trying.

At the pond, the same relationship appeared in another body. Its node watched trends and scheduled checks; a floating robot chose how to move around reeds. Along the road below, a guardian tracked hazards while inspection machines handled their own approach.

The pattern was distributed intelligence made tangible: memory rooted in place, capable bodies carrying out bounded tasks, each with enough independence to refuse an unsafe moment.

A goal could travel without every movement traveling with it.

12

The map beneath the leaves

Leela showed Mira the garden map. It held paths, slopes, bed edges, docking places, and the space a robot needed to turn. Beside it was a world graph: a different view of the same garden, made of things and their relationships.

This tomato belonged to that bed. That probe measured this root zone. Yesterday's water came from this task. The graph remembered identity and connection; the navigation map described geometry. A shared coordinate frame let the two speak about the same place.

TOMO's destination was beside the tomato, where its arm could reach. Driving to the plant's exact position would be a very poor interpretation of visiting it.

Leaves grew. A chair moved. Rain made one patch slippery. TOMO reused its map and updated what had changed, combining observations with movement estimates while watching for wheel slip and uncertain location.

Mira began to understand spatial intelligence as a kind of practical courtesy. It was knowing the space between a wheel and a stem, a person and a turning arm, a destination and a possible way to arrive.

Knowing where a thing was became meaningful when you also knew how to approach it.

A place was more than a picture of itself.

13

A seed receives an address

At the sowing bed, a robot made a small opening in prepared soil. The node created a planting-site record before there was anything green to recognize. Location, variety, date, and care instructions belonged to that beginning.

Days later, emergence would be observed and linked to the same site. A missing seedling would remain a question in the record rather than vanish beneath a new photograph. The plant could change its shape without losing its story.

TOMO's observations carried their own identities too. A measurement included units, source, quality, and the time the condition was observed. The time the node received it was kept separately. A reading collected yesterday and delivered today could teach the history without masquerading as the present.

“So the garden can remember being wrong?” Mira asked.

Leela nodded. Estimates were marked as estimates; raw readings remained distinct from interpretations. If the clock had been uncertain, that uncertainty traveled with the event.

At the edge of the bed, Nila pressed a seed into her palm and studied its small, improbable shape. In the city's memory it would have an address. In her notebook it would have a drawing.

Identity let care continue through change.

14

The garden that could say perhaps

A plant looked thirsty after rain. TOMO's camera showed drooping leaves; its soil probe suggested wet ground. The node held both observations without forcing them into one comfortable answer.

Perhaps the sensor was poorly placed. Perhaps drainage differed across the bed. Perhaps the leaves were responding to something a photograph could not reveal. The next visit was chosen to separate explanations: another measurement at a checked depth, an inspection of the probe, attention to the root-zone conditions.

The node used a modest water-balance model before it used anything elaborate. Water delivered, rain reaching the soil, estimated loss, and drainage contributed to a prediction. Later observations could disagree. The disagreement was useful.

Similar past cases could be retrieved through vector representations, with the search narrowed to relevant plants and conditions. The world graph linked each case to its evidence and outcome. Resemblance alone never opened the valve.

“Does it understand why?” Mira asked.

“Sometimes it has a useful explanation. Sometimes it has a useful next question.”

TOMO took the second reading. The garden could bear a little uncertainty more safely than it could bear an answer invented to end it.

Knowing what to ask could be a form of intelligence.

15

The afternoon the radio went quiet

One afternoon the wireless connection failed. TOMO did not become an empty shell. Its current tasks, limits, expiry times, and completed-action records were stored onboard, where a restart would not erase them.

It finished a permitted inspection. A watering instruction needed fresh authorization, so that task waited. The robot kept enough energy for its return and followed its own map toward the dock, stopping once for a fallen branch and once because its position estimate needed checking.

At the dock, a local reference guided the final approach. Contact confirmed arrival. Charging began, and a data-capable connector exchanged the records that the radio had not carried. A glowing charger alone would not have done that work.

The node and robot reconciled task identities and actual outcomes. One interrupted action had an uncertain delivered quantity. It was marked for assessment instead of being repeated as though nothing had happened.

Mira stood under the shed roof while rain tapped the panels. Return paths could be blocked; connectors needed cleaning; machines could still fail. The dock was a second path, maintained and tested.

On the screen, an unfinished task remained visibly unfinished. That honesty protected the plant.

Memory remained when the conversation paused.

16

Guardians of their patches

The pond node knew the rhythm of its water: temperature across a day, oxygen after a warm night, the level at which a landing should close. It did not pretend to know the tomato bed better than the garden node did.

A roadside node remembered loose debris and drainage near its own bend. An orchard node watched fruit and branch conditions. Tiny sensors contributed observations; more capable boxes maintained local models. A larger neighborhood machine helped with heavier computation when invited.

Size followed local need. A node could be a small sensor, a weatherproof computer, or a data center. Those were different responsibilities, not ranks in a society of machines.

Nearby nodes could relay useful information. Groups could choose temporary leaders for a shared task, then reorganize when conditions changed. No single master had to watch every leaf on the planet.

The flood warning needed to travel. A private conversation in a home did not. Permission, freshness, and relevance shaped each exchange. A guardian's task was bounded care for a place, never ownership of the people passing through it.

From the bridge, Mira saw the modest cabinets scattered among the trees. The city was full of remembering, and still had room for privacy.

Each patch had attention close at hand.

17

A planetary nervous system

On the workshop wall, Nila had drawn the city as a constellation. Garden met pond, pond met river, river met another district beyond the page. Each mark held a local story; each line meant something worth sharing.

The builders called the wider pattern a planetary nervous system. It joined locally grounded intelligence without requiring every reading to pass through one distant brain. A weather change could travel toward the gardens it affected. An observation could carry its source and uncertainty along with its content.

The world as a graph made relationships explicit. Vector retrieval helped find similar experiences. Spatial maps made action possible. Models predicted change, and recorded outcomes gave those predictions something to answer to.

Boundaries mattered. Two nodes might disagree about the rain because rain truly differed between them. A stale message could be refused. A private node could share a flood warning while keeping its other records local.

Mira traced a line on the drawing. It crossed a district boundary, then stopped at a small green circle labeled only by Nila's careful picture of a tree.

However far the network reached, somewhere it had to be right about a particular patch of ground.

The planet could be connected without forgetting its places.

18

The city kept enough memory

The archive did not keep every image forever. Ordinary repeated observations became summaries after their useful detail had been extracted. Important changes and action records stayed long enough to investigate trouble. Models carried versions and a record of where their evidence came from.

The first garden had used a small database for readings, relationships, tasks, and history. More elaborate services arrived only when a measured need justified them. Cloud archives could help, but the root-zone decision did not depend on a distant server remaining awake.

In the workshop, heat, power, and storage were measured as patiently as water. A GPU was useful where its work justified its energy and cooling. TOMO carried the computation its navigation and immediate safety required. Sharing longer-term planning at a node could help several robots, but the builders counted the whole arrangement before calling it a saving.

Mira liked the care given to such unromantic numbers. A city of tenderness still needed spare parts, clean connectors, working batteries, and room to repair things.

Outside, TOMO carried yesterday's outcome back to the garden. The archive could become smaller without the city becoming forgetful.

Enough was a thoughtful design choice.

19

How the beautiful stayed possible

The city's resource room had no price board. It showed water reserves, food stores, energy, repair capacity, and the condition of shared equipment. Removing money had not removed weather, materials, or the hours a machine needed to recharge.

Orchards and fields fed the kitchens. Cooking robots planned batches around reservations and likely arrivals, leaving room for guests who had made no plan at all. Distribution machines brought food close to where people lived. Surpluses were preserved; losses were recorded so the next season could be wiser.

Electricity came from a maintained mix of local generation, storage, and connected supply. Homes, clinics, gardens, and workshops shared priorities agreed in public. Water moved through treatment and reuse systems suited to its next purpose. The river's beauty belonged to that accounting too: flow, cleanliness, access, flood protection, energy.

During a poor harvest, kitchens changed menus. Scarce experiences used fair turns. Basic provision did not disappear because someone had less influence or had contributed less visibly.

Mira watched a cook taste a different soup from the one planned. It was good. The city had learned that abundance needed stewardship, and stewardship could arrive without a bill.

The dream still knew where its water came from.

20

The first garden was smaller

In the oldest workshop was a photograph of the first trial bed. No river city stood behind it. There were a few tomato plants, a marked path, a node, a dock, and a robot being watched by a person with a notebook.

The first proof was a complete loop: find the same plant again, gather a trustworthy observation, deliver a controlled amount of water, record the result, and return. Sowing and skilled harvesting belonged to later work, after movement and watering could be trusted.

The builders tested sensors and delivered volume at the bench. They measured navigation, docking, and unwanted contacts. In shadow mode, proposed care decisions were compared with a simple baseline before the robot controlled watering. They deliberately disconnected the radio and tested the return, the pause, the physical synchronization, and the handling of uncertain actions.

Two nodes exchanged one useful update before anyone spoke confidently about a planetary network. Acceptance criteria came before the trial; results included conditions, failures, and human interventions.

Mira leaned closer to the photograph. The imagined city had begun with a task small enough to finish and a record honest enough to improve.

TOMO was the smallest complete instance. The city grew from learning what that instance needed.

One tended tomato could contain a direction.

Toward the stars

The generation that builds for the spacefaring generation.

21

The generation that planted departure

The observatory was built above a greenhouse. To reach the stars in the evening, the children first walked past tomatoes in warm rows.

Their models of distant habitats were full of familiar questions. Where would water return? What happened when a sensor failed? Could a robot find its dock without a message from Earth? How would a small community keep a shared memory through a long interruption?

The generation building the city understood itself as preparing for a spacefaring generation. Some would never leave Earth. They still worked on reliable care, closed material cycles, repairable machines, and intelligence that could live close to what it served.

In Nila's model, an orbital node remembered the greenhouse while a small TOMO tended its plants. Other nodes marked stations and service points. A traveling craft could carry its own world model and exchange useful local information when it reached another place.

Mira looked from the model to the real vines below the glass. The scale had changed, but care remained particular: this reservoir, this valve, this leaf turning toward a lamp.

The children were building a route outward with skills first learned while keeping something alive nearby.

A garden could be an apprenticeship to the stars.

22

Stations in the dark

In the dream Nila described, a spacecraft approached a small service station with the unhurried precision of TOMO returning to its shed. It had traveled on stored plans, watched its reserves, and carried a record of the journey.

A satellite node held local traffic information, docking references, and the condition of available equipment. The craft checked the message and its age before trusting it. Another station, farther on, had its own memory and its own limits.

At a compatible dock, energy could pass from a station's power system into the craft's storage. Some journeys required propellant or other supplies instead; a node could coordinate a service only where the actual hardware and resources existed. Nothing in the dark was fed by intelligence alone.

Inside the little greenhouse, a robot inspected a tomato plant. Earth was a blue curve beyond the window. Mira imagined a person tasting that first ripe fruit far from rain.

The chain of places would never abolish distance. It could make distance more habitable: a reliable arrival, an honest record, a repair, a supply waiting where a previous generation had placed it.

Even among the stars, someone would need to check the seal.

The future could leave a light on for the next arrival.

23

The things we chose to carry

At the departure exhibition, the children were asked what a city should send into space. Their first answers were practical: water systems, seeds, tools, spare parts, medical supplies, power, maps.

Then a girl added music. Someone else wanted a library in many languages. Nila drew a long table. A boy wrote that every habitat should have a window where a person could sit without needing to do anything useful.

Mira thought of the generations who might build such places and never see them. They would leave diagrams, tested joints, repaired assumptions, and ways to share a small world without making every shortage an excuse for power.

The city's machines could do its necessary labor. They could not decide on humanity's behalf what deserved its freed hours. Those hours belonged to friendship, discovery, grief, play, art, contemplation, and forms of care no sensor could fully describe.

Under the greenhouse glass, a teacher tied a child’s loose shoelace while a companion robot held the notebook dry. The gesture was too small for the exhibition wall. Mira thought it might be the most valuable thing there.

A spacefaring generation would inherit whatever its elders practiced close to home.

Kindness was something to learn before departure.

24

The old habit at the table

It happened during a small gathering after the concert. Someone asked who had contributed most to the river restoration. The question was warm, almost casual. Soon names began collecting around it.

Mira felt the familiar movement inside herself: the wish to be mentioned, the fear of having done too little, the tiny calculation of where she stood among the others. Money had vanished from the table. Comparison had found an empty chair and sat down.

One of the river builders paused. “There were people who did things nobody saw,” she said. “And people who could not join us this season.”

They spoke of the work: which planting held the bank, which approach failed, what should be repaired next. They thanked people by name where thanks belonged. They did not turn the gratitude into a list of better and lesser lives.

The moment passed, but Mira kept it. A beautiful city could not depend on everyone becoming perfectly generous. It would need ways to notice when admiration hardened into rank, and ways to loosen it again.

Across the water, a robot was clearing the last chairs. The difficult part of the evening had required no machine.

The old hunger for a higher place could still visit.

25

Glory with nowhere to buy a gate

Leela had helped design the earliest kitchens. People loved her for it. She could tell a story and gather a crowd without raising her voice. Mira wondered whether influence might become the city's next currency.

“It can,” Leela said. “We have to pay attention.”

The people who changed a food schedule did not gain the right to decide who deserved dinner. A celebrated builder could not reserve the waterfront forever. Technical authority was limited to a task, recorded, reviewed, and passed on. Decisions that affected common life had routes for challenge.

There were no contribution scores following people from place to place. The city's records could measure a pump's reliability without measuring a person's worth. Invitations, affection, and disagreement still existed; none became a condition for a home or a meal.

Mira thought of how easily gratitude could become obedience when one person controlled what another needed. Here the work was to keep thanks free of that hidden debt.

Leela took a bowl from the kitchen shelf and washed it herself because she was standing there. A humanoid beside her continued stacking the others. For a moment, her much-loved name was simply the name of someone next to a sink.

Admiration did not come with a key to anyone’s necessities.

26

The person on the bench

For several days, Mira saw the same man sitting beneath the fig tree. Sometimes he watched the river. Sometimes he slept. She had seen no sign of what he contributed.

The thought embarrassed her as soon as she recognized it. She had been learning the city and had brought an old measuring instrument in her pocket.

One afternoon she sat at the other end of the bench. The man offered a quiet greeting. They watched a floating robot pass beneath a bridge. After a long while he told her that his sister had died in the winter.

There was no lesson attached to the telling. He did not need grief to make him acceptable, and she did not need to uncover a hidden achievement to defend his place there. The bench, the fig shade, dinner later: none had been waiting for his explanation.

When Mira left, she brought him a glass of water. She did not enter it anywhere.

The city made contribution possible without making survival its reward. A person could be useful, recovering, uncertain, old, young, or simply tired. Belonging remained beneath those changing seasons.

— Some days, being held was enough.

27

From comparing to contributing

Nila came home unhappy because another child's model bridge had worked better than hers. She knew the city had no prizes for the best child. Her disappointment had not received that information.

Leela sat beside her and studied the broken span. “What did you want it to carry?”

“The little delivery robot.”

They measured its wheels. Nila asked the other child how the stronger joint had been made. By evening the two models had become one bridge, broad enough for the robot and beautiful enough for Nila's improbable painted flowers.

No announcement followed. Nobody declared them the city's most collaborative children. They rolled a basket of tomatoes across and ate some of the tomatoes afterward.

Mira watched the pleasure return to Nila's face. It had found an object in the world: a crossing that worked, a friend beside it, something useful now possible. That pleasure did not need someone else's failure to stay alive.

Competition had not been defeated in a grand argument. On this particular afternoon, comparison had loosened its grip when attention moved toward what the bridge could give.

There would be other afternoons. The city had made room to practice.

The question became: what can we make possible together?

28

The gate that was gone

On her last morning, Mira woke with the old fear again. It arrived before thought: What if I am no longer wanted? What if I cannot keep up? What if someone who dislikes me can take away the life I need?

Then she heard water beneath the window. Breakfast would be there. Her room was hers to rest in. A disagreement yesterday had not changed her right to care today.

She understood why the robots had never been the whole story. Their work mattered because it helped loosen the dependence through which people could govern one another's survival. Food, shelter, essential energy, and access to ordinary life were shared foundations. Nobody's approval was the private tap from which they flowed.

There were still decisions, limits, repairs, and difficult people. There were processes to question and relationships to mend. The city had not finished being human.

But a lever had moved. Mira could leave an unkind room without leaving the possibility of dinner behind. She could say no. She could offer kindness without secretly purchasing security.

At the garden gate, TOMO was waiting for the snail again. Mira sat on the low wall and waited too.

Love had more room where fear held fewer necessities.

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Make life beautiful

That evening Mira stayed. She had stopped calling the room a guest room and placed her own small plant on the windowsill.

Below, the river carried lantern light through the gardens. A kitchen humanoid closed a cupboard. An orchard robot came home with its empty baskets. The pond guardian recorded a quiet reading. Somewhere beneath the trees, a node kept the history of a day that no single machine had needed to hold entire.

TOMO returned to the tomato bed. There would be another observation tomorrow, another changed leaf, another reason to revise a plan. There were many robots like TOMO across the city, each bringing capable hands, wheels, or patient movement to the care of a particular place.

At the observatory, children were looking outward. The generation building their departure had left the greenhouse lights on. At the fig tree, someone had set down two cups.

Mira opened her window. The city smelled of wet earth and dinner and jasmine. She could not name a single measure that contained the value of this evening. She did not try.

On the workshop door, almost hidden by a climbing rose, were four simple words.

Make life beautiful.

— And tomorrow, begin again with care.

About this imagined city

City of Tomo is an imagined future, written from Ilak's TOMO concepts. Its river city, shared provision, robot capabilities, and orbital habitats are fictional scenes, not descriptions of a completed product or a demonstrated economic system.

The engineering passages adapt TOMO: The Planetary Nervous System; its seven-slide talking points and narrated-presentation script; and TOMO: Technical Architecture with its seventeen-section technical talking points. These materials describe proposed architecture and validation work. TOMO begins with supervised mapping, inspection, and controlled watering; advanced manipulation, city-scale coordination, and space applications remain future possibilities.

The sound-garden scenes imagine bounded experiments. They do not establish that music improves crops or that acoustic treatments can replace chemical pest management. No universal plant frequency or pest-control performance is claimed. The no-trench node scene describes an installation option requiring suitable power, communications, thermal management, protection, and maintenance. Space servicing requires physical energy and supply infrastructure.

The book also develops the ten ideas supplied for this commission and previously shared concepts about contribution, distributed nodes, and a spacefaring generation. Original X posts could not be independently retrieved, so no invented post quotations or claim of a complete X archive is included. Illustration scenes and supporting characters are fictional. The pictures are newly generated concept illustrations; they are not engineering drawings or prototype photographs.

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Make life beautiful.

A garden remembers. A city cares.
A generation leaves a light for the next.